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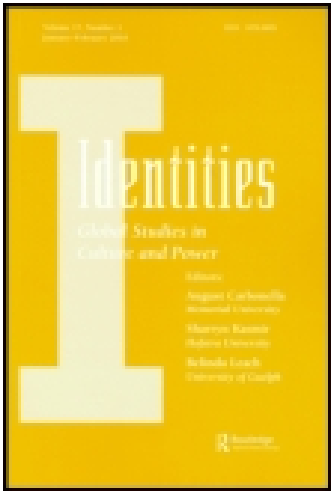

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The symbolics of blood: Mestizaje in the Americas

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The Symbolics of Blood: Mestizaje in the Americas

Carol A. Smith

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Mestizaje, a significant process of identity formation in Latin America based on presumed race mixture, rests on certain sustaining ideologies about race, class, gender, and sexuality that are specific to Latin America. This essay attempts a preliminary discussion of how *mestizaje* has affected marriage and gender relations in several Latin American regions as the marital/kinship pattern, together with its sustaining ideologies, changed over time. Questions are asked about differences in beliefs held by different kinds of individuals (mestizos and "whites," lower classes and elites, women and men) about *mestizaje* and the sexual and/or kinship relations appropriate between different races and classes. Examination of a few well documented historical cases suggests that what lower-class mestizos believe about race, class, gender, and sexuality involves resistance to as well as acceptance of elite beliefs about them. It appears that there are also significant differences in beliefs held by mestizo women and men about appropriate female and male sexuality, though we have less information about this.

Key Words: *Mestizaje*, Race, Class, Gender, Ideology, Latin America

In the conquest societies established in the New World during the colonial period, the biological and cultural origins of peoples came to play a more important role in determining political rights than they had in the Old World, where religion, class, and character

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were the more significant attributes (cf., Stolcke, 1991). Ideologies concerning race,[1] class, and culture throughout the Americas developed some of their peculiarities because of the violent decimation of the native peoples of the hemisphere and the importation of millions of African slaves to provide labor to the most devastated parts.[2] Other distinctive features were provided by the extremely brutal extractive colonial context. In any event, the role and position of mestizos, thought to have ancestors from both the Old World and New, were distinct from those of people considered to be Indians or New World Spaniards (i.e., criollos).

In this essay I attempt to depict some of the underlying regularities in Latin American ideologies concerning mestizos in the postcolonial period. In the colonial social hierarchies of the New World, the political position of mestizos was liminal in that they had none of the specific political rights held by either Indians or Spaniards (whether Old World-born or criollo). As far as the Crown was concerned, they did not have a juridical existence. After three and a half centuries of conquest social relations, however, almost all people in the New World *were* mestizos—of mixed "blood" and/or culture—whether they were officially identified as such or not. But there was resistance to identifying oneself as mestizo, and people who were labeled mestizos continued to have a distinct and marginal social status after Independence in the emerging Latin American nations because of their putative social origins.

The social origins of mestizos involved not just their "mixed" biological background, but their presumed "illegitimacy" of birth. For the mestizos of the colonial period were thought to be mainly the bastard children of indigenous women (or African slave women) who were the concubines (or rape victims) of Spanish men. Patricia Seed observes that in Mexico in the 16th and 17th centuries "most interracial sex took place outside of marriage and the [Spanish] men who desired to marry their concubines were ... so few that they posed little threat to [the racial hierarchy] in society as a whole" (1988: 148). She notes that more than half of the offspring of mestizos in the colonial period were illegitimate. The way in which mestizos were reproduced in the colonies obviously changed over time. Some people labeled mestizos were the children of mestizo women married to mestizo men. Many, however, continued to be the illegitimate children of "outside" unions between native or African women and Spanish men. In consequence, the sexual positioning of the mother of the mestizo was always questionable. As the

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Mexican intellectual Octavio Paz (1961) put it in the 20th century, mestizos are *"hijos de la chingada"* or "children of a seduced and/or violated woman." Hence the social origin of the mestizo also had to do with the social and sexual status of his or her mother.

The process of *mestizaje*, or the way in which mestizo identity was socially and ideologically constructed in Latin America, therefore, was not at all simple. It varied over time, over place, and with respect to how its constituent elements (race, class, culture, gender, and sexuality) were themselves constructed. We can best understand the significance of mestizo social and cultural identity by comparing the way in which those identities were formed historically in different parts of the Americas. Thus, while I concentrate on Latin American *mestizaje*, questioning much of the received wisdom about how mestizos were positioned in Latin America, I will make reference to and comparisons with the way in which "non-white" identities were constructed in other parts of the Americas (i.e., the United States, Brazil, and the Caribbean) over the same historical period in order to make my case about the distinctive features of Latin America.

SOME AMERICAN REGULARITIES IN RACE/CLASS/GENDER IDEOLOGIES

Some two or three decades ago, anthropologists and historians carried out the basic comparative research on the colonial and modern hierarchies of race and class in Latin America, Brazil, the Caribbean, and North America (cf. Harris, 1964; Mörner, 1967). They pointed out that North America has a bipolar racial classificatory system wherein people of mixed descent (mestizos and mulattos) are not distinguished as a group but are rather lumped with others thought to be entirely non-white. In bipolar racial classifications, those of mixed descent are categorized with the most depreciated group, i.e., mestizos with Indians, mulattos with blacks. In Latin America, like Brazil and the Caribbean, people of mixed descent are ranked between those of presumed European descent and those presumed to be entirely African or Indian.[3] Few of the early scholars, however, considered the role that gender and sexuality played in affecting the positions and status of mestizos and/or mulattos. The main exception is V. Martínez-Alier, who analyzed marriage, race, and class in 19th-century Cuba (1974). Martínez-Alier was the first to note that race and class

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position affected the marital and sexual options of men and women very differently, especially in a conquest situation. Her work became influential among Caribbeanists, but not among Latin Americanists.

What Martínez-Alier learned from analyzing the influence of gender and kinship relations on racial and ethnic categories in the colonial social setting of 19th century Cuba is suggestive. She found the following general patterns: (1) elite preoccupation with family status, honor, and purity of blood; (2) an exaggerated double standard of sexual conduct for men and women—which differed significantly for upper-class and lower-class women; (3) an equation of biological (racial) mixture, illegitimacy, and dishonor; and (4) a large number of (dishonored) woman-headed households among mixed-blood, lower-class peoples.

R. T. Smith (1988, 1992), who carried out ethnographic research in Guyana and Jamaica in the modern period, has argued that the four elements noted by Martínez-Alier for 19th-century Cuba remain important throughout the Caribbean today (see also Trouillot, 1990, who describes 19th and 20th century Haiti). Of the four elements, the most commonly noted has been the fourth: the large number of woman-headed households among mixed-blood, lower-class peoples of African descent. North American racist concerns has led politicians and scholars to focus on what has been termed the "abnormally unstable" marriages of the non-propertied descendants of African slaves throughout the New World (see Baca Zinn, 1989). R. T. Smith terms this marriage/kinship system matrifocality or a "dual-marriage system" and observes:

> There is no dispute over the accuracy of the 'facts,' broadly conceived. Vast amounts of survey data have been collected, both in the Caribbean and in North America, and all show the prevalence of high illegitimacy rates, relatively unstable unions, and complex domestic relations in which women play a prominent part. What is lacking is adequate understanding of the meaning of these data (1988: 8).

Following Martínez-Alier, Smith argued that one must position the marriage system of lower-class West Indians within the class system of marriage in order to understand it properly. He also observed that most students pull out of context (and blame the "victim" for) a more general pattern involving all the different races and classes in the Americas. In this pattern, the European upper classes played a key role—perhaps *the* key role (1992).

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Supporting Smith's and Martínez-Alier's thesis, the "dual-marriage pattern" is equally common among other relatively poor and powerless peoples in the hemisphere—specifically, poor Latin American mestizos. Despite the fact that all Latin American families have typically been portrayed as extremely patriarchal and stable, patriarchal family systems have actually been found only among upper-class elites who identified themselves culturally (and racially) as of European heritage. Stable marriages among poorer mestizos have been and are relatively rare throughout Latin America. Current rates of woman-headed households among lower-class mestizos in Central America, for example, are about 50 percent—whether in Guatemala, Honduras, Nicaragua, or El Salvador.[4] And in these woman-headed households one finds little resembling patriarchy—although one does find machismo.

Those few Latin American specialists who have noted the unstable mestizo marital pattern have suggested that the high rate of woman-headed households among lower-class mestizos can be explained by the high rates of plantation labor migration, noting the parallels with the Caribbean region (see, for example, Gonzalez 1984).[5] But there are problems with this thesis. Woman-headed households are extremely rare among Guatemalan Maya Indians, who have made up the bulk of the migratory labor force in Guatemala since the plantation economy was implanted there (see Ortmayr, 1991; Bossen, 1984). The pattern, moreover, occurs widely among lower-class *urban* mestizo families in Guatemala, where males are *not* part of the migratory workforce. In fact, the pattern has been identified throughout Latin America among groups of different social origins and in widely varying economic circumstances—whether labor migration was common or not. It has been described in detail for colonial and 19th-century Mexico (Seed, 1988; Arrom, 1985); colonial and modern Peru (Silverblatt, 1987; Deere, 1991); 18th and 19th century New Mexico and northern Mexico (Gutiérrez, 1991; Alonso, 1988); 19th century Colombia (Jiménez, 1989); and modern Central America (Gould, 1990; Bossen, 1984; Ortmayr, 1991). This broad distribution suggests that it is a consequence of conquest and colonization rather than material circumstances (underdeveloped or impoverished economies) or the flowering of any "primordial" sentiments—by native Americans, Africans, or even the rapacious Europeans. The thesis is also supported by Ann Stoler's (1991; 1992) discussion of the same

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marital/kinship pattern among "mestizos" in Dutch and French colonies of the 19th century in Southeast Asia.

I would argue that the four race, class, gender elements identified by Martínez-Alier for Cuba are general to the Americas wherever the *mestizaje* process took place in an extremely hierarchical social setting supported by some kind of extractive economy. In other words the pattern was common to colonial Brazil and the Caribbean, the southern United States (see Fox-Genovese, 1988; Domínguez, 1986), and *most of Latin America*. The colonial race, class, gender system was distinct mainly in those parts of the Americas where class distinctions were limited—i.e., in what became the northern United States and Canada. With modernity, the family/kinship elements rearranged themselves with other kinds of kinship principles in slightly different ways in the various regions of the Americas. But the four elements mentioned above appear to have continued as the basic ideological precepts[6] generating American race, class, and gender hierarchies. The important part of the pattern is that the political and sexual rights of male Europeans and their white (criollo) and mixed-blood (mestizo/mulatto) descendants affected marriage and kinship among virtually all classes and races in their milieu. And the pattern played out differently for men than it did for women, as the following case material describes.

THE COLONIAL CONSTRUCTION OF MESTIZO "FAMILY VALUES" IN LATIN AMERICA

In a recent article, Verena Stolcke (1991) described the "racist ideological constructs of Europe, and particularly Spain, that served to justify the conquest and colonization of [Latin] America" (1991: 24). I use this account to generalize about the Latin American family pattern because it is the depiction most widely accepted by those few Latin Americanists who have treated the linkage between race and gender inequalities in Latin America (cf. R. T. Smith, ed. 1984). Stolcke begins by explaining how Spanish beliefs about honor and religious "purity of blood" were transformed under the socio-economic conditions of New World colonialism into racism in both the slave and non-slave colonies:

> The very fact of the Conquest, of the domination and exploitation of the local population, produced a profoundly unequal society. But that inequality need not have been codified on the basis of racial differences. In Spain, status was determined by a variety of factors: hereditary

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> nobility, religious affiliation, sex, and even—in limited spheres—proofs of merit (skill, prowess, etc.). But in the colonies, the physical and cultural differences of the indigenous, and later African–American, peoples took on a profound political and social meaning, one that marks Latin American societies to this day (1991: 24).

Stolcke does not directly argue, but she does suggest that as mestizos were produced (by rape and conquest) they fully accepted the inequalities embedded in the evolving hispanic ideological precepts. Why mestizos would embrace an ideology that asserted their inferiority to Europeans is something we have to question, however. Otherwise we concede the "naturalness" and inevitability of European cultural precepts about race. As I go through Stolcke's account, therefore, I pose these sorts of questions, noting those parts of her analysis that need revision.

Stolcke notes that the "ubiquitous concubinage between white men and Indian or black women" cannot be attributed to the scarcity of European women in the Spanish colonies, for "as of the mid-16th century there was no such scarcity" (1991: 26). Spanish women were brought to Latin America early to "safeguard the stability [of the colonies] by whitening them" (1991: 27). The Spanish conquerors, such as Hernan Cortés and Pedro Alvarado, had irregular liaisons with indigenous women, but most of them eventually married Spanish women. The Spanish women became their "legitimate wives," whereas non-white women were maintained as concubines, which produced the classic interaction of race, class, and legitimacy criteria for determining position in the colonies. Illegitimate birth became a sign of "infamy, stain and defect," stemming from the mixture of races (Stolcke 1991: 28). The only guarantee of position and social prestige was marriage between equals—i.e., between men and women of the same class and socially recognized race.

In this way a "dual marital strategy" was produced, wherein men of European descent established legitimate monogamous marriages with women of their own race and class (whose offspring became their legitimate heirs), while maintaining irregular liaisons with non-European women (whose offspring they rarely recognized). At the same time elite men felt the need to safeguard vigorously the purity of "their" women from men other than their legitimate spouses, especially from men of lower-ranking social origins. (See, e.g., Seed, 1988: 172, on colonial Mexico.) From Stolcke's discussion we are not clear whether European men

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insisted on their sexual rights over non-European women out of primordial male lust—i.e., because such sociobiological behavior is "natural" among all men—or for political reasons, i.e., to establish their political authority and/or biological superiority over those conquered. Nor does she make clear why European women accommodated to a sexual standard very different from that of their men. What argument is being made makes a difference when it comes to understanding where and how the colonial American symbolics of blood changed—if, indeed, it did change.

Several essays in a recent collection on colonial sexuality and marriage edited by Asunción Lavrin (1989) suggest that elite women (socially constructed as "white") accepted male restrictions over their sexuality and even labored to reinforce them because elite women who contested this definition of their social honor could be "declassed" by their men—i.e., grouped with women of the lower social orders and treated as such (see especially the essays by Socolow, Twinam, and Calvo). These essays also suggest that class and race status defined sexual options for women in general. The vulnerability of all women to having their class status redefined based on their sexual behavior gives us further insight into how racism and gender oppression deepened as colonial social structure evolved. Men's political rights and women's sexual and marital rights were linked to blood or lineage, yet women's class position was dependent on the men to whom they were legally married. These colonial precepts affected the forms of mating open to the darker-skinned, lower-class woman assumed to be of mestizo heritage, at the same time enforcing a strict code of sexual conduct for the lighter-skinned, upper-class woman of European or criollo background.[7] The same race/class/gender ideology that excluded women from political power (for their potential disloyalty) assigned power to men based on the sexual conduct and lineage of their women—both their wives and their mothers (see C. A. Smith, 1995).

Toward the end of the colonial period economic restrictions on class mobility were loosened throughout Latin America in order to create a freer labor market, basic to fully realized capitalism (Stolcke, 1991: 27). At the same time, however, state laws regulating elite marriage became increasingly stringent, enhancing parental power to block "inappropriate" marriages (in both race and class terms), thus protecting elite "family honor."[8] Notably, these laws excluded from consideration "mulattos, Negroes, natives, and individuals of similar castes and races held and publicly reputed as

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such" (Stolcke, 1991: 27), who presumably had no family honor to protect.[9] Most colonial historians assume that the increased labor mobility and social freedoms of mestizos (especially vis-à-vis native populations) also encouraged further biological mixing among the non-elite, because mestizos emulated elite social and sexual patterns by establishing regular and irregular liaisons with indigenous women (see, for example, Chance, 1978). Whether biological mixing increased in this period because subaltern peoples accepted the conquest ideology, *or because they rejected it*, however, is not established in any of the accounts. Since the social "fact" of *mestizaje* does not establish the beliefs or objectives of those producing it, this part of the account needs to be problematized—especially since mestizo men and women may have had very different objectives from one another.

The growing numbers of mestizos and mulattos in the Spanish American empire threatened a social order where position by social origin, color, lineage, and class was assumed to be purely aligned and immutable (Stolcke, 1991: 26). In consequence, mestizos were considered by colonial elites less of a mediating or "middle" group than impure transgressors of the social order. Only as independent nations in Latin America attempted to construct a post-colonial national identity, were mestizos in some parts of the region officially touted as the true "Americans." White criollos, however, maintained their higher status ranking.

MESTIZO IDENTITY AND "FAMILY VALUES" IN THE INDEPENDENT STATES OF LATIN AMERICA

After Independence, as capitalist economic relations in the New World also expanded, "scientific" racism came to replace the metaphysics of purity of blood. Linked to the beginnings of the social sciences, scientific racism stemmed from the appearance of social reality—that Europeans had dominated people of color for three and a half centuries—and became a rationalization and a means of justifying and perpetuating that reality as European thought shifted from a religious to scientific orientation (see Saxton, 1990). The advantage of scientific racism over the earlier form is that it helped mask the contradiction between an emerging individual meritocratic doctrine and the unequal social reality of what was becoming a class (as opposed to "caste") society (Stolcke, 1991: 28). To justify existing inequalities of race, class, and gender, and to reproduce

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them over time, the dominant (white) ideologues explained them not by the inequalities of material inheritance—which is what in fact reproduced them—but by inequalities of *biological* inheritance.[10] In this way the proclaimed "freedom and equality of all men" in capitalist society could be reconciled with perceived inequalities. Collapsing phenotypical, cultural, and social traits and applying them to people of different origins (American, African, European), the continued dominance by Europeans could be explained biologically. The result was a sociopolitical and cultural elitism grounded in theories of biological class superiority. In this way racist dogma (biologistic explanations for social phenomena) deepened even further in Latin America, even though racial mixing was officially encouraged.

Why racial mixing was officially encouraged in Latin America, but not in North America, has been discussed and explained in many different ways (demographic as well as ideological), none of them entirely satisfactory.[11] Perhaps the most common explanation is that the white elites of Latin America were so outnumbered by mestizos that the only realistic homogeneous national identity they could forge—grounded in popular consent—was that of mestizo. Mexico, for example, believed itself in 1991 to be 35 percent Indian, 50 percent mestizo, and 15 percent white (criollo); Argentina, in contrast, believed itself to be 90 percent white in the same time period and did not promote racial mixture—but rather promoted continued European immigration (Stepan, 1991: 139). A number of scholars have noted that those Latin Americans who promoted race mixture did so because of their belief that it "lightens" or "improves" the race (Stutzman, 1981 on Ecuador; Williams, 1990 on Guyana; Knight, 1990 on Mexico; Burdick, 1992 and Skidmore, 1973 on Brazil).

Of all the Latin American countries, Mexico most fully idealized *mestizaje* or "racial amalgamation." Nancy Stepan (1991) depicts Mexico's celebration of *mestizaje* in the 1920s as a simple inversion of the European devaluation of racial hybridization or mongrelization in the same period and directly links the Mexican promotion of *mestizaje* to the eugenics movement that was taking off then in both Europe and the Americas. The Mexican "cosmic race" supposedly brought about by widespread *mestizaje* in Mexico derived from what its champion and ideologue, José Vasconcelos (1944), described as a "eugenics of aesthetic taste." Vasconcelos thought that a form of selection based on beauty would eliminate African

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traits and "conjoin only the superior individuals of all races [into] a eugenic, mestizo race" (Stepan, 1991: 147). As Stepan notes, "it is important to recognize the degree to which Mexico's idealization of *mestizaje* was fundamentally structured by the racism of the period ... reflecting anxieties about Mexico's racial (and national) identity" (Stepan, 1991: 149).

Most Latin Americanists now concede that racism is as real and pervasive in Latin America (including Brazil and the Caribbean) as it is in North America (see Knight, 1990; Skidmore, 1993; Burdick, 1992; Wade, 1993). The difference, they argue, is that racism is more fully internalized among the mestizos of Latin America and the mulattos of Brazil and the Caribbean, whose people of mixed heritage identify with the most rather than the least oppressed in racial terms. Whether or not one wants to consider Latin Americans to be as racist as North Americans, it seems clear that Latin American assessment of *mestizaje* remains highly ambivalent.

State policy in modern Latin America also encouraged the acculturation or hispanization of the mestizo. Efforts were made to eradicate any Indian and African cultural residue through state education—which basically celebrated Europe's (rather than America's or Africa's) contribution to the nation. Thus the message projected about mestizo race and culture in Latin America remained extremely contradictory. On the one hand, mestizo "race" in Latin America is largely defined through culture rather than phenotype or color. A publically identified mestizo can be virtually any biological mixture—from all Indian/African to all European—but must have acquiesced to the dominant "national" culture, severed kinship ties with community members of non-European culture, and speak Spanish. On the other hand, despite rhetoric eulogizing mixture and the cosmic race, mestizos of lighter skin are typically more highly evaluated than those of darker skin—especially as "legitimate" marriage partners. In Mexico and Brazil (countries with especially strong *mestizaje* ideologies), for example, darker mestizo men can acquire positions of power without the difficulties faced by African-Americans or Latinos in North America. But they typically do not challenge the racism/biologism of the evaluative system that depreciates their color, instead accommodating to it by seeking to "lighten" their progeny by acquiring a lighter-skinned wife. (They might prefer a darker-skinned sexual partner, but would maintain such a woman as a

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concubine rather than as a legitimate wife.) Because elite men rarely marry a woman "darker" than themselves, class position remains essentially "biologized" today in both Mexico and Brazil.

From this it would appear that mestizos do fully "identify with" their social superiors, the white elite. Presumably by doing so mestizos acquire certain political and economic rights denied to those who resist cultural incorporation or ideological domination—even if they do not gain full social equality with those of European origins (cf., C.A. Smith, 1987; 1990; Mallon, 1992). If one assumes that mestizo men have simply appropriated conquest ideology about race, class, and gender, one has little difficulty explaining the existence of sexually predatory values rooted in conquest, i.e., "machismo," among *both* white and mestizo males. (And this *is* the common assumption.) In parallel fashion one can derive the female counterpart of machismo, "marianismo," wherein both white and mestizo women welcome abusive male behavior as the spiritual verification of their true womanhood (see Stevens 1973). But are these reasonable assumptions? In order to ask this question without prejudging the answer, it will be useful to examine in some detail what was at stake between mestizos and higher-ranking groups, and between mestizos and lower-ranking groups on several different dimensions simultaneously—economic, political, and sexual—as mestizo race/class/gender ideology developed. We must also interrogate the assumed homogeneity of the mestizo, considering at least the possibility that male and female mestizos held different positions on these issues.

MESTIZO COMPLICITY IN AND RESISTANCE TO ELITE "FAMILY VALUES"

There are relatively few studies of the sexual, racial, and class beliefs held by mestizos in contemporary Latin America; there are virtually no historical studies. The most suggestive historical studies I know are those provided by Michael Jiménez (1989), who describes elite and mestizo men and women's struggles over "family values" in late 19th and early 20th century Colombia, and Jeffrey Gould's (1990) discussion of changes in family relations in 20th century Nicaragua. Both depict a period of transformation during the construction of plantation economies—coffee plantations in Colombia, cotton in Nicaragua. In neither case, however,

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did labor migration lead to significant absences of peasant men from their homes—any more than women. What it led to was a pattern of constant contact between elites and workers (both men and women). The traditional peasant family pattern had been much more stable in an earlier period, presumably because the families were relatively isolated from elites. What I describe here, then, is a pattern of family struggle among mestizo peasants who are becoming partially proletarianized; but the vector of change I identify is not labor relations so much as direct contact between elite men and peasant women. Neither Jiménez nor Gould spell out the implications of the situations they describe for understanding mestizo family values in general. But by analyzing the cases in some detail, together with supporting materials from other cases where they exist, I hope to suggest that the mestizo family system resulted from the way in which mestizo men and women struggled against elite class/race "inferiorization" and asserted their autonomy in different and sometimes antagonistic ways.

Jiménez's basic argument is that mestizo family patterns (and values) changed historically in response to forces that accelerated class differentiation among mestizos. His particular study is of the changes wrought by the coffee plantation economy in western Colombia. Most useful is Jiménez's insistence that economic and sexual practices were interrelated among both mestizos and elites:

> [Mestizo sexual conquest practices] were neither a mere ahistorical embodiment of male lust nor a simple vestige of *señorialism*. ... [They] represented the most powerful, if dangerous, weapon at the disposal of the planters in imposing their will on workers; the resulting divisiveness and demoralization of the peasant household was consistent with the goals of maintaining control over subordinates through arbitrary decisions, in this case directed at the very core of their personal and family existence (1989: 132).

He argues that when economic struggle was paramount, mestizo men and women pursued divergent, often contradictory, paths in that battle. Mestizo men dominated their families in hispanic fashion (i.e., with conquest-derived values) mainly when they did not need women to assist in the economic struggle.

Jiménez's depiction of white elite attitudes in the colonial period fits that of others who have worked on colonial Latin America (such as Lavrin 1989), viz.:

> Even as the elite [European colonizers and the Catholic Church] encouraged patriarchy among the rural poor, the intimacy forced by white men

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> on Indian women was commonplace, resulting in rapid miscegenation throughout most of the [area] and institutionalized interclass sexual relations, which undercut male authority among the peasantry (1989: 131).

At this point Jiménez does not argue that the conquerors' predation on non-European women was a way of establishing authority over native/mestizo men. But he does suggest that even though native marital and sexual norms were much freer and more open than European ones at the time, the conquerors sexual use of native women created tensions between indigenous men and women.

Irene Silverblatt (1987), who describes the transformation of native gender ideology under Spanish rule in colonial Peru, pursues this theme more fully. She bases her interpretation on the thousand-page letter written to the Crown in 1613 by Guaman Poma, a minor member of the Inca royalty, literate in Spanish and highly acculturated. Poma describes the rape and abuse of native women by the Spanish conquerors, the attempts of many indigenous women to better their unhappy situation by becoming concubines of Spanish men rather than wives of fellow indigenes, the subsequent rage of native men and their abandonment of family responsibilities, and the resulting collapse of the relatively egalitarian indigenous marriage and kinship system. It seems clear enough that regardless of Spanish motives in this regard, the sexual conquest of indigenous women went hand-in-hand with the economic exploitation of both men and women in native communities.

According to Jiménez, from the mid-16th century onward patriarchal values were common to both the white elite and mestizo peasants in rural Colombia. In his words, the men of both groups believed that women were ruled by a near demonic sexuality, which made them different from men; hence, women (incapable of self control) were to be regarded ultimately as possessions of men, their sexuality to be controlled by their husbands and fathers. In the countryside a "relatively stable" peasant family pattern was established among mestizos once the colonial economy was organized; by implication rural (peasant) mestizo women were rarely the concubines of Spaniards. It appears, in fact, that mestizo women were rarely even in contact with people other than spouses and kin in the countryside. We have somewhat more information on the situation for urban mestizo women in the Spanish colonies, where many women worked outside of the household and seemed to maintain many more options. Martínez-Alier (1974) suggests that mixed-blood women were frequently chosen as concubines in

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urban Cuba and Arrom (1985) found that mestiza women in Mexico City in the 19th century were relatively autonomous in familial terms.

The expansion of coffee plantations in 19th-century Colombia seems to have changed the peasant mestizo family pattern. In Jiménez's account, the new economy, which turned some mestizos into agrarian capitalists and others into part-time peasants and wage workers (both men and women), vastly increased cross-class contact between men and women. "Landlords humiliated their dependents through verbal and physical abuse and sexual harassment; yet there was also a close identification between [males of] the two classes, who lived and worked together [in the early stages of estate formation]" (1989: 129). In the "complex psychological combat" in which peasant men engaged with landlords, they sometimes "collaborated in the sexual predations of their masters" which momentarily put "the masters in their lust at a disadvantage to lower-class men" (1989: 133). But most peasant men sought to "protect" their womenfolk, by keeping them from working on the estates or moving freely about. This set male peasants, who were in a "continual state of alarm regarding elite sexual advances to their womenfolk" (1989: 133) on a collision course with both their class superiors and the women of their own class.

Economic opportunities brought on by the plantation economy allowed peasant women to challenge the patriarchal gender ideology. Despite the fact that these challenges brought on severe sanctions, women attempted to establish more open relations with men—"including premarital sexual encounters, single motherhood, common-law marriages, and concubinage" (Jiménez 1989: 135). These relations were relatively rare in the colonial period, though they were always a recognizable alternative to the nuclear family. But such relations flourished during the establishment of coffee plantations in the region and had become dominant by the early 20th century. Illegitimacy rates in the coffee zone, which were quite low early in the 19th century, remained persistently high in the early 20th century. In 1906 three quarters of the births were illegitimate, falling to 63 percent in the late 1920s.[12] What pulled the mestizo patriarchal family system apart was the fact that mestiza women now left their households at a relatively young age to earn incomes. This increased the possibilities for contact between peasant women and upper-class men and brought on new forms of struggle between women and men in the peasant households.

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Of special significance was the acquisition of greater economic autonomy by mestizo women in the coffee plantation period, resulting in conflicts with their social superiors as well as their male classmates. The substantial incomes brought into mestizo households by women acting as workers, food provisioners to the estates, petty merchants, small store owners, and major players in the underground economy meant that they were in a position to demand greater control over their labor in general as well as economic decision making within their families. But women's growing economic and sexual autonomy was not without peril. Rape and other physical violence against peasant women by peasant as well as elite men increased significantly; and brawls between the sexes occurred in homes, marketplaces, and the coffee groves. The frenzied responses by peasant males to real or imaged sexual liaisons of "their" women with others, displayed a rage against poor rural women as great as that against the planters. Jiménez explains it this way:

> The assertion of dignity by peasant men and women in the face of constant humiliation by their class superiors often placed them at cross purposes, especially regarding expressions of sexuality. The persistence of the patriarchal ideal among male peasants undercut their ability to sustain a full range of opposition to the dominant culture. Paradoxically, women's economic involvement—in poaching, tax evasion, and the like—rather than strengthening peasant [class] resistance, strengthened a smallholder economy that came to be dominated by men who eventually pushed or cajoled women back into purely domestic, familial tasks. *For as with property, the legal order, and other issues, male peasants and elites shared a common stance with regard to gender identities and relations* (1989: 140, 142, emphasis added).

In other words, Jiménez reads the evidence that women were "cajoled back into purely domestic, familial tasks" when peasant economic resources permitted to mean that mestizo gender antagonism (based on male concern about the loyalty of their women) blunted mestizo (worker) class solidarity. But the establishment of a "smallholder" coffee economy, even if it moved women from the fields back into the home can also be read as a sign of successful mestizo struggle in which lower-class men and women cooperated economically to resist full proletarianization and sexual exploitation and basically won out over elite landowners, in both class and sexual terms. After all, the smallholder economy also moved men from the fields back into the home. And it had the general effect of consolidating mestizo family resistance to individual proletarianization—which increases individual choices for *both* men and women.

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Jeffrey Gould (1990) describes a similar case of "patriarchal" family breakdown among mestizos in Nicaragua, when a plantation economy was established there in the 20th century.[13] Whereas in the 19th century, "stable" marriage was common among rural Nicaraguan peasants, in seven out of ten departments where permanent wage laborers constituted more than 60 percent of the rural labor force in the 1920s the illegitimacy rate was 40 percent or higher. As the plantation economy spread, so did female-headed households. Women headed close to 25 percent of all rural households in 1950, more than half of all Nicaraguan households by the late 1970s. But according to Gould, "rather than seeing the disintegration of the nuclear family as a direct consequence of migratory labor, the increase of single mothers derived indirectly from peasant strategies to resist proletarianization through the urban migration of their daughters" (1990: 227).

Let us look at the logic of Gould's argument about peasant strategies, building on the pattern of household and gender conflict among mestizos described by Jiménez. According to Gould, between 1900 and 1950, many peasant *fathers* in the newly developing plantation area of Nicaragua sent their daughters to work in towns. These daughters became market traders (20 percent of the total female municipal labor force in 1963), more became domestic servants (38 percent of the female work force in 1963), and some became prostitutes (one department, with a total population of 128,000 in 1963, had over five hundred houses of prostitution). Gould implies that economic opportunities were expanding for women with the plantation economy. It appears, however, that the real beneficiaries of this economic expansion were not mestiza women, but rather their families of origin (i.e., their fathers), who presumably received income from their working daughters. How much peasant women welcomed these opportunities we do not know.

Gould observes that antagonism increased between men and women as mestiza women moved out from the control of patriarchal authority. As they moved out of their fathers' households into unprotected working arenas, they faced much greater sexual risk as well as choice:

> Elite males used and abused their servants sexually and often boasted about their "conquests." Sexual liaisons between an elite man and his female domestic often continued until the woman became pregnant. The pregnancy "dishonored" the lady of the house, who often demanded

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> that the servant be fired and expelled. The dismissed domestic servant could usually find work only as a seamstress or in the marketplace. Her family often would not accept her home again (when village morality was not an issue, economy always was). In the dense steamy *barrios* stretching out toward the countryside from whence they came, the often stigmatized peasant women would raise their children in extreme poverty, the outside children of the elite (1990: 229).

As in the coffee region of Colombia described by Jiménez, the "sexual relations between elite men and lower-class women symbolized elite *class* domination, female complicity in its rule, and, by implication, lower-class male impotence" (1990: 232), poisoning relations between mestizo men and women:

> The male workers' reaction to the women's liaisons with the *señores* was one of scorn rather than compassion. ...While male workers and peasants detested elite men's "deflowering of women," they also bitterly resented what they perceived to be female acquiescence to the elite *conquista*. Finding it difficult to confront their own feelings of inadequacy and power-lessness directly, many working-class men reproduced elite machismo and promiscuity. In making their own *conquistas*, working-class males added to the number of single mothers while at the same time stigmatizing them (Gould, 1990: 230).

Here again, the analyst may be jumping ahead of the evidence. It is possible that women's acquiescence to elite sexual *conquista* divided mestizo men and women into antagonists. But it could also be that lower-class men and women both wanted more sexual and reproductive freedom than the patriarchal family allowed. And individuated wages for both men and women (as opposed to an interdependent smallholder economy) provided that freedom. In any event, we find in this case, as well as in the case described by Jiménez, significant changes in the mestizo family pattern: i.e., greater sexual promiscuity (by both men and women), the breakdown of classic patriarchy, rising rates of concubinage, illegitimacy, and male sexual predation, and considerable gender antagonism. We also find an explanation for why economic transformations that expanded employment possibilities to mestizo women transformed mestizo social behavior in ways that can only be considered contradictory.

Laurel Bossen (1984) describes essentially the same gender antagonism among lower-class Guatemalan mestizos (ladinos) in both the plantation areas and the urban barrios of Guatemala, centering on women's sexual and employment freedoms. Roughly two thirds of the women interviewed by Bossen (half in an urban squatter

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settlement, half in a rural plantation area) were not legally married and most had had more than one sexual partner over their lifetimes. Because these women worked, most outside of the home, they were sexually suspect. Those few women who were legally married were mostly married to men who had stable employment; these men could (and did) "demand a high degree of control over their wives' activities, typically seen in a curtailment of sexual freedoms and social relationships outside the family" (1984: 167). Bossen points out that sexual suspicion affected the relations between mestizo men and women, leading lower-class men to reproduce elite machismo and promiscuity. And she suggests that the women who were most successful economically were also those most likely to be abandoned by their men. In her view, many lower-class women resisted the sexual standard that disadvantaged them economically, whereas most elite women bought into the conquest ideology because they benefitted from it in class terms.

We know very little about the racial ideologies of these lower-class mestizos. Jiménez does not treat Colombian beliefs about race at all. Gould suggests that Nicaraguan indigenous communities (as opposed to mestizo communities) usually took single mothers with their illegitimate children back into their communities and "considered the mestizo children Indians" (1990: 231). He interprets this to mean that Indians transcended "a strictly physical notion of ethnicity ... [strengthening] their own ideological concept of Indian" (1990: 231). Presumably mestizos were not so accepting, tending to see independent mestizo women as disloyal and opportunistic and maintaining a more "physical notion" of ethnicity.[14] But what Nicaraguan mestizos thought specifically about racial groups and sexuality Gould does not describe.

Bossen does not treat contemporary mestizo beliefs about race and sexuality, but Marta Elena Casaus Arzú (1992) provides an extended comparison of white and mestizo racial ideology which she analyzed through interview materials gathered in the early 1980s. Casaus Arzú shows that "the self descriptions of white Guatemalans do not correspond to the objective reality, given ... the intrinsic difficulty of considering oneself white in societies that have suffered the process of *mestizaje*. Based on physical features, their genealogical charts, and historic anecdotes, not one of them could call themselves white" (1992: 212). Yet over the past several hundred years white Guatemalans were much more careful than mestizos to select their spouses from the same limited endogamous

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group self-identified as white—or from the U.S. and Europe. Guatemalans who identified themselves as white rather than mestizo and who by independent measures were also the richest and most powerful Guatemalans in the study, held much more racist beliefs about Indians in Guatemala than mestizos did. One of Casaus Arzú's white informants said, "I would never allow my daughter to marry an Indian ... because they are an inferior race and our obligation is to improve the race, not to make it worse" (1992: 245). Another white informant argued:

> The only solution for Guatemala is to improve the race, to bring in Aryan seeds to improve it. On my finca I had a German administrator for many years and for every Indian he got pregnant, I would pay him an extra fifty dollars (1992: 289).

Casaus Arzú documents that mestizos also held racist beliefs. They were much less racist than the beliefs held by whites, however.

Finally, Diane Nelson reports the following about race and sexuality in contemporary Guatemala:

> *Mestizaje* [in Guatemala] is produced through overdetermined power differentials of race and gender that both allow the rape of indigenous women by [mestizo] men and allow that rape to be described as desired by the woman—either because of her lust or for material gain [a narrative which shows] the 'obvious' superiority and desirability of the [mestizo] male. However, mestizo men's insecurity and ambivalence about such violence and whether they are 'white enough' also clearly troubles these stories. The body of this 'mestizo'—produced from an illegitimate union between a mestizo man and an indigenous woman—could only be materialized through the cultural symbolics encoded in these power differentials ... and [his] 'physical' features do not stand alone but can only be read through this complex of social relations (1995: 15).

These case materials, some historical and others contemporary, of the relations between race, class, and gender in Latin America are all partial accounts, most of them leaving out at least one of the three relevant elements. Reading between the lines, however, we see that mestizo family values are very much contingent upon the actual position of the mestizo who holds those values: his or her color and phenotype; his or her class, economic options, and interactions with other classes; his or her age and family position; and of, course, his or her gender and sexuality.

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CONCLUSIONS AND REMAINING QUESTIONS

These cases do not provide a simple answer to the question of whether or not mestizos resisted or accommodated to an elite patriarchal family standard. Many lower-class mestizo men did align themselves with and identify with dominant elite men against *all* women. Rather than seeing lower-class women as fellow workers or classmates, these mestizos saw women as individually owned male property that must be protected from other men—of all classes. Any sexually accessible woman, moreover—whatever her original class or race position—became equivalent to all others: a "piece" of already claimed male property that had lost value to other men. For these men, a woman retained her value to a man (of any class), only by remaining virgin until marriage and socially isolated from non-kinsmen (of all classes) after marriage. This cross-class male understanding of women as property aligned men of all classes with each other against all women, thus bolstering male power and privilege in both classes. But it also positioned men of all classes as competitors with one another in the game of sexual conquest.

As Jiménez points out in his discussion of the Colombian case, this portrayal of mestizo men does not assume that men are inherently (biologically) anxious to "conquer" all women or to have as many biological heirs as possible. It assumes only that under the property relations of the New World, ownership and control of female labor (and progeny) is claimed and established by men of all classes and races through sexual conquest. Lower-class mestizo men thus take on the machismo and promiscuity of elite men in order to assert their basic equality with elite men. Rather than being an act of ideological subordination, it is an act of resistance.

At the same time, however, these cases suggest that lower-class mestizo men and women sometimes formed alliances against the upper classes. They were able to do so mainly when economic conditions favored economic interdependency between lower-class men and women—as in maintaining a smallholder economy. When individuated through wage labor, men and women often (but not always) pursued non-collective family/sexual patterns. The Colombian case suggests that even in these circumstances men and women could cooperate to resist their full proletarianization and sexual vulnerability to men of the elite. And whether they won or lost in such struggles, mestizo women defined themselves as labor, reproducers, and sexual beings in a very different way from either

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elite men or women. The degree to which they allowed mestizo men to classify them as honorable and dishonorable varied depending on their economic strength.

What we need to explore now are some of the variations in the way these standards developed in the New World in response to their particular conquest experience. Why was class division more important than race division in some areas, while the opposite was true in others? What were the circumstances that allowed a relatively egalitarian gender ideology to emerge? And where was the conquest ideology most fully contested. We know that some kind of conquest ideology became hegemonic throughout the Americas. But "the manner in which the acts and axioms of a [hegemonic] world-view actually come to be naturalized . . . is always historically specific" (Comaroff and Comaroff, 1991: 25).

NOTES

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1. Throughout this paper I mean by "race" the conflation of social origin (Europe, Africa, native America) and "color" or phenotype that is embedded in "American" racial/racist discourse.
2. Most Latin Americans and many Latin Americanists forget that the numbers of African slaves brought to the Spanish colonies equalled or exceeded the number of Spanish settlers and they were mainly absorbed into the mestizo category (see Mörner 1992, Lutz 1994).
3. Since the African heritage of many Latin American mestizos was socially "forgotten" by the end of the colonial period (except in Brazil), mestizos were presumed by most Latin Americans (and most Latin American scholars) to be of European and indigenous mixture; hence the term mulatto is not a term of common usage in Latin America (except in Brazil).
4. For statistics as well as an interesting discussion of women-headed households among lower-class mestizo women in Guatemala see Ortmayr, 1991 and Bossen, 1984: 133-245. For recent Nicaraguan statistics on women-headed households, see Lancaster, 1992: 38; Lancaster's book discusses the women-headed household among lower-class mestiza women ethnographically as well. For statistics on

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El Salvador, which has one of the lowest marriage rates in the hemisphere, see Dunkerley 1982: 67; there is relatively little ethnographic treatment of family relations in El Salvador. An excellent discussion of family relations among lower-class mestizos is Medea Benjamin's (1987) collection of Elvia Alvarado's personal testimony; Honduran country-wide statistics on women-headed households are not available.

5. What is interesting about those who note the pattern in Latin America, like Gonzalez, is that they observe it among people of partial African descent (like the Garifuna) and link it to the African-American pattern of the Caribbean. Yet the pattern is equally common among Latin American mestizos (of indigenous-European descent), as the figures I report on Central America indicate. There has been very little treatment of the pattern among Latin Americans who are not of African heritage, however.
6. I borrow the concept "ideological precepts" from Brackette Williams, who develops Gramsci's notions of common sense and hegemony to define it as follows:

   [Cultural precepts are] rules and standards, often expressed in principles, maxims, or proverbs, which declare the world to be of a certain composition and to work in a certain way. Precepts become ideological when they are linked to politically privileged interpretations of human experiences which ignore or consider irrelevant information that contradicts the logic of these rules and standards (1993: 184).

7. According to Ann Stoler (1989, 1992) very similar beliefs about race, class, and gender evolved in Southeast Asia under the conditions of colonialism, white supremacy, and the threat that *mestizaje* posed to white supremacy. This suggests that the conquest marriage and kinship pattern I have described here is as much a functional relationship as a cultural precept.
8. In 1776, Charles III, the Bourbon king of Spain, issued the Royal Programmatic that changed the rules governing marriage. For the first time parental permission was required for marriages and disputes were placed under the regulatory power of a civil court; the rule was extended to the American possessions two years later (see Martínez-Alier, 1974; Seed, 1988).
9. Seed (1988) argues that the Royal Programmatic was passed in the latter part of the colonial period in the New World because of the wishes of the criollos (or white elites), who were increasingly challenged in their position by successful mestizos.
10. Given the link between capitalism and imperialism, the notion of fit races made a lot of sense to both lower and upper classes in the centers of the very unequal capitalist world-economy, which first based itself upon the production of basic commodities with the labor of African slaves, Indians, and other non-white serfs, and indentured lower classes from all over the world.
11. Recent critiques of the Tannenbaum thesis, which is that Catholics and "Mediterraneans" (such as Portuguese and Spaniards) were less race prejudiced than Protestants and Anglo Saxons can be found in McGlynn and Drescher, eds., 1992, along with varieties of economic and demographic explanations for the differences.
12. These are illegitimacy rates reported in census statistics rather than by parish priests. Arrom (1985) observes in her study of urban Mexico that census takers

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almost always considered consensual unions to be real marriages and the children of such unions to be legitimate. The high illegitimacy and low marriage rates reported here, therefore, are not an effect of the high rate of consensual unions not blessed by the clergy, the usual explanation for these rates in the Latin American literature.

13. The two main cases of patriarchal family breakdown that I investigate here *are* associated with the expansion of plantation economies. In neither of these cases, however, were spouses or male and female workers separated by the labor regime. The plantation economy seems to be the precipitating cause of family breakdown because of the economic options it offered women, ending their involuntary isolation from unrelated men. I suspect that anthropologists have found an association between unstable marriages and plantation economies in rural areas for these reasons. It is important to keep in perspective, however, that concubinage and unstable marriages were long common in urban areas without plantation labor migrations. Anthropologists just rarely investigated urban kinship.
14. Gould describes a case where the relationship of one peasant mestizo woman with an elite man came to symbolize the immorality and dishonor of an entire mestizo community. He notes that community blame for this relationship fell primarily on the woman, assumed to be opportunistic, rather than on the class exploiter, who was clearly much more opportunistic (1992: 232).

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